

Wu's tax bid declared 'dead' on Beacon Hill

New data undercut mayor on relief for residents

By Niki Griswold and Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Mayor Michelle Wu's proposal to soften property tax increases on Boston homeowners collapsed Monday in the state Senate after a top Democrat declared the bill "dead," dealing Wu a high-profile political loss just as the first-term mayor heads into a reelection year.

Hours after the comment by Senator Will Brownsberger of Belmont, whose district includes parts of Boston, Senate President Karen E. Spilka confirmed the chamber would not take up the bill again, all but putting an end to what has been a contentious, monthslong saga. Wu sought the authority to shift more of the city's property tax burden onto commercial real estate in order to lessen an expected spike for homeowners, ultimately hatching a compromise with business groups that scaled back the more extreme increases she originally sought.

Yet, even with support of House Democrats, Wu's proposal crumbled in the Senate, underscoring her lack of pull in the upper chamber months after she publicly quarreled with its top leader. The setback wasn't a minor one: Wu invested as much,

TAX BILL, Page A12

US probe cites police abuses in Worcester

Officers said to have had sex with suspected prostitutes

By Shelley Murphy and Dan Glaun
GLOBE STAFF

The Justice Department said Monday that a two-year civil investigation of the Worcester Police Department found a series of rule violations, including that officers had sexual contact with women suspected of prostitution while working undercover and that they rapidly escalated minor incidents by using unnecessary force against people who were in a mental health crisis.

A 43-page report detailing the findings said the investigation raised serious concerns that officers "have sexually assaulted women under threat of arrest and engaged in other problematic sexual conduct."

Police also committed civil rights violations by using excessive force, the report found, such as the use of tasers, police dogs, and strikes to people's heads, according to the report.

The department's "inadequate policies, training, and supervision" contributed to the abuses, the report said. **WORCESTER POLICE, Page A12**

Spit, into the wind

Tuesday: Drizzle early. High 40-45, low 37-42.

Wednesday: Gusty storm. High 63-68, low 35-40.

Weather and comics, **D5-6**.
Obituaries, **C12**.

Packed into cage-like trucks, thousands of Haitians have been deported from neighboring Dominican Republic. **A4**.

Some Nantucket businesses missed out on their busiest day of the year — the island's 50th annual Christmas stroll — because of a power outage. **B1**.

Suspect charged with CEO's slaying

Police say man, 26, had a weapon, fake ID, manifesto critical of health care firms

By Ed Shanahan
NEW YORK TIMES

The tipster's call to local police came in shortly after 9 a.m. Monday from a McDonald's in western Pennsylvania.

The caller said that a customer looked like the man in photos

shared by New York authorities who were searching for a suspect in the brazen killing of a health insurance executive in Manhattan last week.

When officers arrived at the McDonald's, they approached the customer, Luigi Mangione.

"He was sitting there eating," Joseph E. Kenny, the New York Police Department's chief of detectives, said at a news conference.

Mangione was wearing a blue surgical mask, according to a criminal complaint. The officers asked him to pull down the mask.

When he did, one of the officers, the complaint says, immediately recognized him as the man being sought in the killing of the executive, Brian Thompson.

Protecting staff

CVS removed photos of its executives from its website. **A9**.

Asked by the officers whether he had been in New York recently, the complaint says, Mangione "became quiet and started to shake."

By Monday night, prosecutors in Manhattan would charge him with Thompson's murder.

SUSPECT, Page A9

OILY WINGS AND A PRAYER



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

Zak Mertz (right), CEO of New England Wildlife Center, attempted to coax a bird into a net so that it could be cleaned and treated for any injuries. The bid was part of a two-day effort to rescue birds affected by an oil spill in the Muddy River in Brookline. Staff from the center were aided by other groups, including Boston Park Rangers. **B1**.

Freed from yoke of despotism, Syrians still freighted with doubts

By Christina Goldbaum and Hwaida Saad
NEW YORK TIMES

DAMASCUS, Syria — Syrian security checkpoints sat empty Monday across Damascus. Tanks were abandoned across the roads, along with pieces of military uniforms stripped off by soldiers when opposition forces stormed into the city a day earlier.

Rebels with rifles slung over their shoulders drove around, many seemingly shocked at just how quickly they had ousted Syria's long-entrenched president, Bashar Assad. Damascus residents, too, were walking around the city's streets in a state of disbelief.

Some rushed to a notorious prison on the outskirts of Damascus, the capital, desperate to find loved ones who had disappeared. **SYRIA, Page A6**



METIN YOKSU/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Displaced Syrians waited to cross into their country from Turkey near the town of Antakya on Monday. **A6**.

appeared under Assad's brutal reign. Others clambered on top of cars and screamed curses at the Assad family, words that days ago could have meant a **SYRIA, Page A6**

Israeli incursion

Troops seized military posts in the south of Syria, sending its troops across the border for the first time since the Yom Kippur War in 1974. **A6**.

Jan. 6 defendants confident Trump will deliver pardons

By Jim Puzzanghera and John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

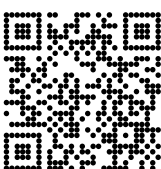
WASHINGTON — William Pope was finally set to go to trial this month on charges related to the Jan. 6, 2021, Capitol insurrection, one of more than 1,500 people prosecuted for their actions during the violent attempt by Donald Trump's supporters to overturn the 2020 election results.

Then Trump won the 2024 election, putting his vow to pardon those defendants potentially within months of becoming reality.

Pope, a 38-year-old Topeka, Kan., man representing himself on several nonviolent charges, quickly moved for a delay. "The American people gave President Trump a mandate to carry out the agenda he campaigned on, which includes ending the January 6 prosecutions and pardoning those who exercised First Amendment rights at the Capitol," he wrote to the court.

Prosecutors countered that Pope's "expectations" were unrealistic. **PARDONS, Page A8**

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